

COLD WAR, HOT WAR

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THE PRIME DRIVING FORCE BEHIND technological developments in aviation in the 40 years after the end of World War II was the Cold War confrontation between the Western allies and the communist bloc. The imperative of national defense in a nuclear age made competition for the edge in performance intense and unabating. The result was remarkable progress in aircraft design, jet engines, avionics and weaponry. Meanwhile, shooting wars were fought in many parts of the world, in which air forces tried out the latest technology in action. In the post-Cold War period from the end of the 1980s, air power remained prominent as a means of enforcing the will and protecting the interests of states advanced enough to possess the latest technology.



NORTH AMERICAN X-15

Moments after being dropped from its Boeing B-52 mother ship, a rocket-powered X-15 research plane begins a flight into the upper atmosphere. The X-15 flew faster than any other airplane, reaching over six times the speed of sound.